To understand what happened and why, any history must start with the political environment between Washington and Beijing in the years leading up to the war, as well as look at the military assets each possessed and assess the balance of power in the western Pacific at the outset of hostilities. Only then will analysts be able to interpret the political and military decisions taken by both sides.

I. The Political Background

The influence of existing political relations on subsequent policy decisions is often downplayed by historians attempting to assert that rational actors had clearly articulated reasons for choosing a path that led to armed conflict. Yet the decade before the outbreak of war between China and America witnessed a steady erosion in Sino-US relations that poisoned the various links built up between the two nations since the 1970s and made crisis management increasingly difficult. The Cold War paradigm established by Richard Nixon and Jimmy Carter, where the United States sought to play the PRC and Soviet Union off each other, had evolved during the Reagan administration into a more transactional approach that sought to develop Sino-US relations for their own sake while attempting to get Beijing's support for US policies that pressured Moscow, such as in Afghanistan and Cambodia.

With the end of the Cold War, American policy makers turned to constructing a new great-power relationship with China, despite growing strains between the two countries. Though the George H. W. Bush administration largely downplayed the regime's Tiananmen Square massacre of prodemocracy student demonstrators in June 1989, the Clinton administration sent two aircraft carriers to the Taiwan Strait in March 1996 after Beijing fired ballistic missiles off the island during Taiwan's first presidential campaign.[1] Yet under administrations of both political parties, Washington steadily attempted to integrate China into what liberal internationalists called the "rules-based international order." Thus, the Clinton and George W. Bush administrations